



Eating well

A guide to diet
and bowel cancer



Bowel CancerUK
Beating bowel cancer together

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About this booklet

This booklet has information about how your diet can affect and improve your symptoms during and after bowel cancer treatment.

After treatment, you may find you can't eat the same foods as you did before. These changes may be temporary or they may be longer-lasting.

We've included a food and symptoms diary at the end of this booklet on [page 41](#), to help you find out how different foods may affect you. We've also explained some of the words we use in this booklet on [page 42](#) and listed contact details for useful organisations on [page 43](#).

If you've recently been diagnosed with cancer or if you're having treatment for cancer, speak to your healthcare team for diet advice.

Support for you

As well as the information in this booklet, we also have a range of other information and support that you might find useful.

Online Communities

Join our forum and facebook groups for everyone affected by bowel cancer at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk/online-communities](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/online-communities)

Ask the Nurse

Contact our nurses if you have any questions or concerns at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk/nurse](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/nurse)

Publications

Order or download our free publications at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk/ourpublications](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/ourpublications)

Website

Find out more about bowel cancer at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk)

Support events

Learn about the disease from experts at our support events for those affected by bowel cancer, including family and friends at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk/supportevents](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/supportevents)

What is a balanced diet?

It's important to follow a healthy, balanced diet and keep active to help you feel physically and emotionally well.

Your balanced diet will be individual to you. It will depend on your age, weight, gender and how active you are.

The foods you can eat may vary during and after your cancer treatment and you may find you can't eat the same foods as you did before your bowel cancer diagnosis. Eating a balanced diet is important but mealtimes should still be enjoyable, so it's ok to have some of your favourite food and drinks too.

We have more information about what to eat before, during and after treatment later on in this booklet.

The NHS website has an Eatwell Guide, which shows how much of each food type to include in your diet. Remember, this is general information so you may need to change it to meet your needs during and after cancer treatment.

You may hear about diets that claim to help people with cancer by cutting out types of food, such as dairy. There is often no evidence that these work and some can be harmful.

Tips for following a balanced diet

- Eat at least five portions of vegetables and fruit each day
- Eat more wholegrain variety carbohydrates, such as bread, pasta and rice, unless your healthcare team has advised you to follow a low-fibre diet
- Eat some lean protein, such as skinless chicken, fish or pulses each day
- Include some lower-fat dairy or non-dairy alternatives in your diet
- Cut down on saturated fats and sugar
- Drink six to eight glasses of fluid each day – water is best but if you struggle to drink enough, you could try drinking sugar-free squash, tea or coffee instead. You could also try eating food that contains water, such as soup or melon

You should be able to get all the vitamins and minerals you need from a healthy, balanced diet.

Remember

Always speak to your healthcare team or a dietitian before making any big changes to your diet.

Before surgery

Eating a healthy, balanced diet can help you recover from surgery more quickly.

Foods high in protein, such as chicken, fish and eggs, can help your body heal and lower the risk of wound infection. If you don't eat meat, you can get protein from lentils, soya products, tofu, beans, nuts and seeds.

Fibre-rich carbohydrates such as wholegrain bread, rice and pasta are a good source of energy.

Many hospitals have an enhanced recovery programme. This includes offering you carbohydrate-rich drinks for a few days before and after your operation. This is to help with healing and recovery after surgery and may shorten your hospital stay.

During treatment

Cancer treatment can affect your appetite and your ability to eat and drink. It can also affect your senses of taste and smell. If you feel sick or are being sick, you may not feel like eating.

Tips for eating during treatment

- If you have a low appetite, try eating smaller meals more often during the day
- If you're not eating much, you may not be getting enough nutrients from your food. Try high-calorie or 'build-up' drinks. You can buy these from pharmacies or your dietitian may give you a prescription for them
- If you feel sick, you could try drinking ginger or peppermint tea, or eating ginger biscuits. Eating a small amount of plain food every two to three hours can help. Avoid fatty, spicy or strong-smelling foods
- If you have a sore mouth, you could try eating soft or liquid foods, such as porridge, smoothies, soups, well-cooked casseroles and stews. Avoid acidic or spiced foods
- Speak to your GP or healthcare team if you're still not eating or drinking enough. They may refer you to a dietitian or give you treatment to help you get the nutrients you need

More information

You can read more about eating with a low appetite on [page 17](#) and eating when you have fatigue on [page 22](#).



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The chemotherapy made me sensitive to cold temperatures, so I warmed up my drinks. This helped me to stay hydrated too.

JV

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After treatment

The following pages suggest how you can include the important food groups in your diet when you're recovering from bowel cancer treatment. If you've recently been diagnosed with cancer or if you're having treatment for cancer, speak to your healthcare team or dietitian for advice.

Vegetables and fruit

Vegetables and fruit are an important part of a healthy, balanced diet and are rich in vitamins, minerals and fibre. Aim for at least five portions each day, ideally more vegetables than fruit, and include a range of different colours and types.

Vegetables and fruit are a good source of fibre, which helps keep your digestive system working well. You can read more about fibre on [page 14](#).

You may need to follow a low-fibre diet during and after treatment. Your healthcare team will give you more information about this. You can read about low-fibre diets on [page 16](#).

Some people find they're not able to cope with eating some types of fruit or vegetables. For example, some vegetables, like broccoli, cauliflower and Brussels sprouts can cause symptoms such as wind. The diary on [page 41](#) can help you find out which foods might be causing your bowel symptoms.

One portion could include:

- 30g of unsweetened dried fruit – eat at mealtimes to reduce the risk of tooth decay
- 80g of fresh, canned or frozen vegetables or fruit – choose canned varieties in natural juice or water, with no added sugar or salt
- 80g of beans or pulses
- 150ml of fruit or vegetable juices or smoothies – have no more than one portion a day

Examples of portion sizes



Handful of grapes



One banana



One pepper



One cereal bowl of spinach



Three heaped tablespoons of beans, peas or lentils

Starchy carbohydrates

Starchy carbohydrates are a good source of energy. You should eat some carbohydrate every day. You can get starchy carbohydrate from foods like bread, pasta, cereals, rice and grains and starchy vegetables, such as potatoes and sweet potatoes.

Unless your healthcare team has advised you to follow a low-fibre diet, limit your intake of white varieties of bread, pasta, rice and skinless potatoes. Choose wholegrain varieties and leave the skin on potatoes. Wholegrain foods often contain more nutrients and fibre, helping you feel full for longer. You can read more about fibre on [page 14](#).

Protein

Protein is important for cell growth and repair and for helping your body recover after surgery or cancer treatment.

Good sources of protein include chicken, fish, eggs, beans, peas and pulses, tofu, nuts and seeds. You may need to be careful about how much you eat of some types of protein:

- Nuts and seeds have high levels of fat, so keep to a modest handful each day
- Nuts and seeds are high in fibre, so don't eat too many if your healthcare team has advised you to follow a low-fibre diet
- Other plant-based foods, such as beans, peas and pulses can make diarrhoea and wind worse, so you may not be able to eat large amounts. Read [pages 28](#) and [35](#) for information about diarrhoea and wind

Examples of protein sources



Chickpeas or beans



Eggs



Tinned fish

While meat is a good source of protein and iron, eating a lot of red meat may increase the risk of bowel cancer. Red meat includes beef, pork, lamb, venison and goat. Eat no more than three portions a week. This is about 350g–500g of cooked meat a week.

Try to eat smaller portions of red meat. One portion is about the size of a deck of playing cards. You could choose lean or low-fat varieties or cut off any fat. You can make meat go further in sauces and stews by adding vegetables, beans or lentils, if you can eat them.

Try swapping red meat for chicken, fish or plant-based meat substitutes, such as soya products or tofu. You could have some meat-free days too. Avoid processed meat, such as bacon, ham, sausages and salami. Eating meats like these can increase the risk of bowel cancer.

Dairy

Dairy foods are important sources of protein, calcium and vitamins. Examples include milk, cheese, yoghurt and butter. Eat some dairy foods each day and choose lower-fat, unsweetened varieties. If you're trying to gain weight, you could choose full-fat dairy foods.

If you eat non-dairy alternatives, look for unsweetened options with added calcium. Other sources of calcium include dried fruit, nuts and leafy green vegetables.

Fat

Our bodies need fat for energy, brain function and as a source of vitamins. You only need a small amount of fat in your diet unless you're trying to gain weight.

Unsaturated fats are healthier and are found in:

- oily fish such as salmon, mackerel and sardines. Aim for one portion a week
- nut and seed butters, such as peanut butter and tahini
- nut oils, like walnut oil
- seeds and seed oils, like sesame oil
- olives and olive oil
- avocados

Check food labels and choose foods with 3g or less of total fat per 100g (1.5g fat per 100ml liquid) where possible. These labels are sometimes colour-coded green.

Saturated fats are less healthy. Try to choose foods with 1.5g saturates or less per 100g (0.75g saturates per 100ml liquid). Foods containing higher amounts of saturated fat include fatty or processed meat, cheese, butter, cream, cakes, biscuits and chocolate.

Supplements

You should be able to get all the vitamins and minerals you need from a healthy, balanced diet. But you may need some extra help. For example, if there are some foods you can't eat, if you follow a vegan or other restricted diet, or if you have a poor appetite. Many vegan foods have nutrients added so it's worth checking the label.

Please note

Don't take high doses of supplements as they can be harmful. It's especially important not to take any vitamins or food supplements during your cancer treatment unless they've been recommended by your doctor, dietitian or other qualified healthcare professional.

Fibre

Dietary fibre is the part of plants that the body can't digest easily, so some of it passes into the bowel without being absorbed. A diet rich in fibre is important for bowel health, as it helps move food more quickly through the bowel and supports the growth of good gut bacteria. Fibre also keeps you feeling full for longer, so can help you control your weight and appetite.

Fibre-rich foods

You may hear fibre being described as soluble, insoluble or fermentable.

Soluble fibre dissolves in water and helps to keep poo soft, making it easier to pass. Good sources of soluble fibre include oats, barley, beans, peas, lentils, chickpeas, vegetables and fruit.

Insoluble fibre bulks up poo and helps it move through the gut more quickly. This may help prevent constipation. Good sources of insoluble fibre include wholegrains such as brown rice, wheat and spelt as well as nuts, seeds, potatoes in skins and dried figs.

Fermentable fibre feeds the good bacteria in your gut. Good sources of fermentable fibre include onions, garlic, banana, wheat, oats, beans, peas and chickpeas.

Fibre-rich foods often contain more than one of these types of fibre.

Adding fibre to your diet

Increase fibre gradually to avoid wind, bloating and stomach cramps. For example, you could add an extra portion of vegetables to your diet every few days. Fibre attracts water so it's important to drink plenty of fluids like water, low-fat milk or herbal teas to help prevent constipation. Avoid sugary or fizzy drinks as these can lead to weight gain.

After treatment, you may find it hard to digest high-fibre foods such as bran, nuts or seeds. Over time, you can try to gradually increase the amount of fibre you eat. But to start with, you can make fibre easier to digest by cooking vegetables and fruit well and removing their skins. You can read about low-fibre diets on [page 16](#).

How much fibre?

Healthy adults should eat at least 30g of fibre a day. Your healthcare team will explain how much fibre you need to include in your diet, depending on which treatment you've had. They can also help if you find that you can't cope with high-fibre foods.

Examples of portion sizes



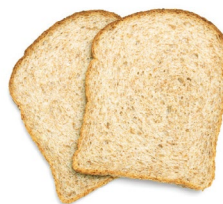
50g bowl of porridge – 5g fibre



One medium banana – 1-2g fibre



Baked potato with skin – 5g fibre



Two slices wholemeal bread – 6g fibre



80g boiled broccoli – 2g fibre



25g unsalted nuts – 1.5-2g fibre

Low-fibre diets

Your healthcare team may advise you to follow a low-fibre diet, for example before and after treatment. Ask your healthcare team how long you should follow this diet. You may be able to gradually start eating more fibre after a few weeks.

You may be worried about how you can eat enough vegetables and fruit if you are following a low-fibre diet. Your healthcare team will give you advice. You could try foods containing soluble fibre, which is easier to digest, such as:

- fleshy parts of vegetables, such as cucumber, peppers and tomatoes, with the skin and seeds removed
- well-cooked vegetables that are lower in fibre, such as courgettes, squash, carrots, parsnips, swede and sweet potatoes
- lower-fibre fruits such as banana, melon, seedless grapes, and peeled fruits such as apple, pear and peach
- tinned fruit in juice (rather than syrup) with no skin, pith or seeds
- frozen berries that have been defrosted and sieved
- fruit juices – only have one serving each day, as fruit juice is high in sugar

Eating with a low appetite

Bowel cancer and its treatment can affect how much you're able to eat and drink.

Speak to your GP or specialist nurse if you're having problems with eating enough. They can give you emotional support and practical help to eat a balanced diet. They may prescribe medicines, for example if you have sickness or a sore mouth.

If you're a family member or carer and you're worried about someone who has lost their appetite, you can speak to a healthcare professional on their behalf.



“

When I was struggling, we often invited friends or work colleagues over for a light social lunch. Enjoying meal times helped me immensely when I had low appetite.

Ian

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Tips for boosting appetite

- Try to make mealtimes enjoyable, for example by eating in a relaxed environment or with friends and having the foods you enjoy
- Eat at similar times each day. Your appetite will start to adjust to these planned mealtimes, which can help you look forward to meals
- Fresh air and physical activity before meals can help you feel hungry. Even a short, gentle walk can make a difference
- If food smells make you feel sick, try to stay away from the kitchen and ask friends or family to cook. Eating foods that don't need cooking may also help, such as cheese and crackers or breadsticks with dip
- Use herbs, spices, pickles and sauces, flavoured olive oils, lemon and lime juice to add flavour to food
- Pre-prepared foods that can be chilled or frozen can be useful if you don't have time to cook or if you aren't able to cook for yourself. Make sure they're reheated properly before eating
- Make large meals that you can eat in smaller portions, such as soup, dhal or lasagne. This allows you to go back for more if you want to
- If you find that you get full quickly, don't drink anything for half an hour before a meal. Only have small sips during your meal, unless you need fluids to help you swallow. Drink more between meals
- If you don't feel like eating, you could try energy-rich drinks, like smoothies

You may also find these tips helpful if you're struggling to gain weight.

Gaining weight safely

What causes weight loss?

Some people lose weight when affected by bowel cancer or its treatment. There may be several possible reasons for your weight loss, such as the cancer itself or the side effects of treatment.

If you're eating normally but still losing weight, the cancer may be affecting how your body absorbs and uses the nutrients in your food.

Side effects of treatment such as constipation and diarrhoea can affect your appetite. Extreme tiredness (fatigue), a change in your senses of taste and smell, feeling and being sick and emotional stress can lead to problems with eating. Getting medical advice and treatment for these symptoms may help you to eat more and put on weight.

How can I put on weight?

To gain weight safely, you need to eat more calories and keep active. Eating several small meals each day can help you eat more calories and digest your food more easily. Try to include energy-rich foods such as

peanut butter or Greek yoghurt to your meals and snacks. Make sure you have the food and drinks that you enjoy.

You could also try high-calorie or 'build-up' drinks with added vitamins and minerals. You can buy these over the counter from pharmacies or your dietitian may give you a prescription for them.

If you feel well enough, try to do some regular gentle physical activity. This can help build up your muscle strength and may help improve your wellbeing. Ask your GP or healthcare team if they can refer you to a physiotherapist who can help you find activities that are safe to do during and after cancer treatment.

Getting support

Speak to your healthcare team if you have lost a lot of weight or if you're losing weight quickly. It's important to find out what's causing your weight loss and if you need treatment.

Losing weight safely

If you're overweight, it's important to speak to your healthcare team before trying to lose weight. They can give you information on which types of food you should eat, depending on the treatment you've had and the side effects you're having.

Following a healthy, balanced diet and eating less can help you lose weight. Regular physical activity also helps. If possible, aim for at least 30 minutes of physical activity, five days a week. If you find this difficult, you could try going for gentle walks and avoiding sitting for long periods of time.

Gradually build up the amount of activity you do and ask for help from your GP or healthcare team if you need it.

Tips to help you lose weight

- Start the day with a healthy breakfast, such as porridge, wholegrain cereals or bread, boiled or poached eggs, lower-fat milk and a portion of fruit
- Choose lower-fat options where available but remember that many low or non-fat foods contain more sugar
- Replace refined starchy foods such as white bread, white rice and white pasta with wholegrain varieties
- Think about your portion sizes. Even healthy food, such as olive oil and nuts, can make you put on weight if you eat too much
- Try to avoid sugary snacks and choose healthier options, such as a small portion of nuts and seeds or some carrot sticks with cottage cheese or low-fat hummus
- Swap creamy, fatty or sugary food and drinks for fruit, vegetables and water
- Keep active and eat healthily most days, including weekends and holidays
- When you're exercising, drink water instead of sugary or sports drinks or fruit juice
- Remember that alcohol contains calories. Drink as little as possible and no more than 14 units a week. A glass of wine or pint of low-strength lager is 2 units

Some people find it helpful to keep a record of their progress. You could weigh yourself once a week or note down how much you eat and drink and how much physical activity you do. You could also ask friends or family to support you. Being active and eating healthily together can help you both keep on track.

Managing cancer-related tiredness

Bowel cancer and its treatment can cause extreme tiredness. This is called fatigue. It can affect you physically, emotionally and mentally. If you're worried about fatigue, speak to your GP or hospital team.

What is fatigue?

Cancer-related fatigue is unlike any other kind of tiredness you may have experienced before. It affects your everyday life and isn't relieved by rest, sleep or caffeine. Fatigue is common in people with bowel cancer, especially during treatment. It can continue for several months or years after cancer treatment for some people.

Preparing meals can be challenging when you have cancer-related fatigue. The tips below can help you cope with fatigue.



“

After treatment, I had no energy, so my parents would help by making me dinner. They would make me light, plain dinner like noodles or broth that was easy to eat and digest.

Ning

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Tips for coping with fatigue

- Try to eat and drink a wide variety of fresh food and fluids to make sure you get all the nutrients you need
- Have some of your favourite foods and drinks. It's important to enjoy mealtimes and look after your wellbeing
- Try choosing healthier ready meals or prepared salads
- Keep portion sizes small and eat five or six smaller meals or snacks a day. This will help to keep your energy levels steady and stop you feeling hungry
- Ask friends or family to help you prepare food. You could also ask someone to help you with food shopping or order your groceries online
- When you feel able to, cook large dishes and then freeze them in meal-size portions. Making several portions of soups and other meals means you can put some in the fridge or freezer for when you don't feel like cooking
- Boost your iron intake. Good sources of iron include dried apricots, green vegetables, beans and breakfast cereals with added iron and wholegrains. Red meat also contains iron but you should limit how much you eat. Read [page 11](#) for information about red meat
- Be as active as you can. Physical activity can help to reduce fatigue and help you cope with treatment
- Try to keep to a regular bedtime routine
- Eat a light snack and have a caffeine-free milky or herbal drink before bed to avoid waking up hungry or thirsty in the night
- Take any prescribed painkillers just before going to sleep if you find that you tend to wake in the night with pain

Eating and drinking with a stoma

Some people have a stoma after surgery. This is where a section of bowel is brought out through an opening on your stomach area (abdomen). Your poo (output) is collected in a pouch or bag attached to the skin around your stoma.

Stomas can be temporary or permanent. There are two types of stoma – a colostomy is formed from the large bowel and an ileostomy is formed from the small bowel.

When you leave hospital, your stoma care specialist nurse should give you information on diet. Try to eat a balanced, healthy diet and drink six to eight glasses of fluids a day.

For the first two months after surgery your bowel will be swollen, so you will need to chew your food well. You may find it helps to eat five or six smaller meals a day instead of three larger ones.

It might take a little while to find which types of food you can and can't eat. The food and symptoms diary on [page 41](#) can help you with this.

If you have your stoma reversed, it can take months for your bowel symptoms to settle down. You may have more frequent or more urgent bowel motions, constipation or loose, runny poo (diarrhoea). You can read about how diet can help with diarrhoea and constipation on [pages 28 and 32](#).

Your healthcare team can offer support and treatment for bowel problems after stoma reversal surgery.



“

I love going to watch rugby at the weekend. When I had a stoma, I ate a small meal before the game so that I wouldn't need to change my stoma bag and could enjoy my day out.

Mike

”

Colostomy

Many people with a colostomy are able to eat a healthy, balanced diet. If you had constipation or diarrhoea before having a colostomy, you may find that you continue to have these symptoms.

You may find that some types of food give you bowel symptoms such as wind or loose poo. Cutting back on these types of food can help.

To help prevent constipation, drink six to eight glasses of fluids a day. Water is best but you can also have tea, coffee or sugar-free squash. Limit fruit juice to one glass a day.

Make sure you're eating enough fibre and have at least five portions of vegetables and fruit each day. For the first few days after surgery, make sure vegetables are well cooked. You may cope better with fruit that's cooked, rather than raw.

Daily gentle physical activity such as walking is also important.

If you have constipation, make sure you're eating regular meals to keep your stoma working. Food that is spicy or high in fibre can help to relieve constipation. If you want to eat more fibre, introduce it to your diet gradually and make sure you're

drinking enough fluids. Read [pages 14 and 32](#) for more information on fibre and constipation.

Contact your stoma care specialist nurse or call 111 if there are any signs that your colostomy isn't working properly, such as:

- watery poo or not passing many poos
- stomach cramps and bloating
- feeling or being sick (nausea or vomiting)
- a swollen colostomy

If you have diarrhoea, speak to your stoma care specialist nurse. They may give you medicine to slow the movement of food through your bowel and thicken the output. You can read more about diarrhoea on [page 28](#). Foods that may thicken your poo include very ripe bananas, boiled rice, porridge, smooth peanut butter, white bread or pasta.

More information

Find out more about stomas on our website at [bowelcanceruk.org.uk/stomas](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/stomas)

Ileostomy

When you first have an ileostomy, you may find that some foods are harder to digest. Your healthcare team may advise you to follow a low-fibre diet to start with (see [page 16](#)). Avoid fruit straight after surgery, except for bananas which thicken the output (poo) from your ileostomy. Raw vegetables can also cause temporary blockages.

Try to drink six to eight glasses of non-caffeinated fluids, such as water, each day. This will help prevent dehydration.

After six to eight weeks, you should be able to start eating more types of food.

You can eat vegetables and fruit as part of a healthy, balanced diet. Try fruit and vegetables that can be cooked until they're soft, such as boiled carrots or stewed apples. To start with, you could try taking off the skin and removing the seeds or eating tinned vegetables and fruit in natural juice or water. Chewing vegetables and fruit well can help avoid blockages.

Eating lots of small, hard foods like raisins, nuts and sweetcorn can sometimes block the ileostomy. You can help prevent this by eating small amounts of these foods and chewing them well. You could try crushing nuts or creaming sweetcorn.

You may sometimes get an increased output of poo from your ileostomy. Possible causes include stomach infections, stress, antibiotics, spicy food, beer or lager. Here are some things you can do to help:

- Keep drinking water to stay hydrated – aim for six to eight glasses a day
- If you're able to, eat salty foods or add a little salt to your meals to replace the salts lost in loose poo. If you have high blood pressure, heart or kidney problems, check with your stoma care specialist nurse first
- Cut back on foods that increase the amount of poo you pass, such as fruit, vegetables, fried foods, fruit juice, caffeine and alcohol
- Thicken the output by eating bread, rice, potatoes, pasta, oats, smooth nut butter, bananas and crackers

Tell your stoma care specialist nurse if you have increased output over a long period of time, feel thirsty or faint, or have dark yellow urine. These can be signs of a high-output stoma, which can cause dehydration.

If your ileostomy stops working, you may have a blockage. This can cause pain in your stomach area (abdomen) and you may feel sick. Contact your stoma care specialist nurse for advice. They may suggest that you:

- keep drinking fluids
- stop eating solid food
- don't use laxatives
- make the opening of your stoma appliance slightly larger if your stoma swells
- massage your stomach area (abdomen) and around the stoma
- try a warm bath to ease pain in your stomach area
- go to the hospital emergency department if you haven't passed any poo or wind from your ileostomy for more than six hours

Important

Get medical help from your hospital emergency department straight away if your stomach area is very painful and bloated and you start being sick (vomiting). Your bowel may be blocked, and you may need treatment quickly.

Diarrhoea

Your bowel habits may have changed after treatment and you may experience diarrhoea. These symptoms may improve after a few months, but some people have longer-term changes. Changing your diet can help to improve your symptoms.

Diarrhoea is loose, runny poo that you pass three or more times a day, or more often than what's normal for you.

What causes diarrhoea?

Bowel cancer treatments, including surgery, radiotherapy and chemotherapy can cause diarrhoea. Other possible causes include your diet, medicines such as antibiotics, and infections.

Some people may have symptoms of diarrhoea when they have constipation. This may seem confusing and you may wonder why your doctor is treating your diarrhoea with laxatives. But if your poo is blocking your bowel, runny poo can leak through and can look like diarrhoea. Your doctor will work with you to find out what is causing your diarrhoea so you can get the right treatment. You can read more about constipation on [page 32](#).

Avoiding dehydration

When you have diarrhoea, you need to drink enough fluids to avoid getting dehydrated. Take regular small sips and aim for at least six to eight glasses of fluids a day. Avoid sugary or fizzy drinks and drinks that contain caffeine, such as tea and coffee, as these can irritate the bowel and make diarrhoea worse.

As well as losing water, you will be losing salts and other important nutrients. To replace these, try eating fresh or tinned soups and broths. You could also have Marmite on toast or plain crackers.

If you feel too sick to eat, or if you become very dehydrated, your GP may suggest you use oral rehydration salts. These contain a balance of salts and sugars to help your body re-absorb them quickly. You can buy them from pharmacies and supermarkets.

What should I eat?

Light, bland and easily digested foods can help with diarrhoea after bowel cancer treatment. Try cutting back on high-fibre foods, such as wholemeal bread, bran-based cereals and brown rice, especially in the first few weeks and months after surgery and radiotherapy. You can read more about fibre on [page 14](#).

Try to eat small amounts regularly throughout the day and eat slowly to avoid bloating and wind. Tell your healthcare team if you're having trouble eating or if eating plain food doesn't improve your symptoms. If you're not able to get enough nutrients from your food, your healthcare team may refer you to a dietitian.

It may take you a while to find out which foods make your symptoms better or worse. You may find that your body reacts differently to foods that you could eat in the past. It's always worth trying foods again to see how you react to them. You can keep a record of how you react to different types of food on [page 41](#). Some people take probiotics to prevent or reduce diarrhoea.

Probiotics are live bacteria and yeasts that improve the balance of bacteria in the gut. You can find them in some food products, such as yoghurts, or in food supplements. Some people find they help with diarrhoea but there isn't enough evidence for health professionals to recommend taking them.

You should not take probiotics during chemotherapy or if you have low levels of white blood cells because they can increase the risk of infection.

Important

Always speak to your healthcare team before taking probiotics.

Suggestions for food and drink to try and what to avoid if you have diarrhoea



Food and drink to try

- Water
- Bananas
- White rice
- Oats
- Pasta
- Noodles
- White bread or toast
- Crackers
- Low-fibre cereals, such as puffed rice or cornflakes
- Skinned chicken
- White fish
- Hard boiled eggs



Food and drink to avoid

- Drinks containing caffeine
- Alcohol
- Milk and other dairy products
- Fatty foods
- Raw vegetables and fruit
- Beans
- Spicy food
- High-fibre cereals, such as bran and muesli
- An artificial sweetener called sorbitol, found in sugar-free sweets and drinks

Diarrhoea medicines

Tell your doctor about any medicines and nutritional supplements you're already taking. They may suggest you stop taking medicines that may be making your diarrhoea worse.

Always speak to your doctor before taking any medicines for diarrhoea. They will need to find out what is causing your symptoms before deciding on the best treatment for you.

Your doctor may offer you medicines that slow down the movement of your gut (anti-diarrhoea medicines). Examples include loperamide (brand names include Imodium or Dioraleze) or codeine phosphate. They will give you information on how and when to take these medicines.

If your bowel cancer treatment is likely to cause diarrhoea, your doctor may give you anti-diarrhoea medicine to keep at home in case you need it. If you're having chemotherapy or chemoradiotherapy, your doctor may give you a medicine called octreotide to treat diarrhoea caused by your cancer treatment.

Contact your healthcare team if you have any questions about how to take your medicines.

Where can I get more help?

Your healthcare team can tell you about products and local services that can help you cope with diarrhoea.

More support

You can also contact Bladder and Bowel UK for information on products to help you cope at home and when you go out.

The Pelvic Radiation Disease Association provides information on diarrhoea and other bowel problems caused by pelvic radiation disease.

You can find their contact details on [page 43](#).

Constipation

Your bowel habits may have changed after treatment and you may experience constipation. These symptoms may improve after a few months, but some people have longer-term changes. Changing your diet can help to improve your symptoms.

Constipation is when your poo is hard, dry and difficult to pass. You may find it painful when you go to the toilet or you may feel like your bowel isn't completely empty.

If you're going to the toilet less than three times a week, you're likely to have constipation.

Speak to your GP or healthcare team if you think you have constipation.

What causes constipation?

Many things can cause constipation, including:

- bowel surgery
- medicines, such as opioid painkillers
- other illnesses, such as diabetes, thyroid problems or depression
- not eating enough fibre
- not drinking enough fluids
- lack of movement and physical activity

Please note

Get medical advice straight away if you haven't had a poo for more than a few days and you have pain, feel sick or have been sick (vomited).

If you have an ileostomy, contact your stoma care specialist nurse or visit the hospital emergency department if you haven't passed poo or wind for more than six hours.

What should I eat and drink?

Always speak to your healthcare team before making big changes to your diet. If you've had constipation for a long time, you may need medical treatment before you change your diet.

- Eat at least three meals each day. Try not to skip meals
- Drink six to eight glasses of fluids, such as water, a day
- If you're able to eat fibre without it causing symptoms, add more to your diet, especially wholegrains, vegetables and fruit. Do this gradually and in small portions to avoid wind and bloating

When you're recovering from treatment, high-fibre foods should be well-cooked and chewed well. This makes them easier to digest. If you're adding more fibre to your diet, make sure you're drinking more fluids to avoid getting dehydrated. Be careful not to overdo it. Eating too much fibre can make constipation worse. It can take a few weeks for you to see any change in your bowel habit. You can find out more about fibre on [page 14](#).

Foods that may help:

- Wholegrain bread, rice, pasta and breakfast cereals
- Porridge oats
- Fresh, tinned or dried fruit that is high in a natural laxative called sorbitol. For example, prunes, raisins, plums, grapes, peaches, raspberries, strawberries, apricots, apples or pears
- Fruit juices high in sorbitol, such as prune juice
- Vegetables
- Peas, beans and lentils
- Ground flaxseeds/golden linseeds

Other things to try:

- Regular physical activity
- Avoiding sitting down for long periods of time
- Making sure you have enough time and somewhere private to go to the toilet, if possible
- Sitting in a squatting position on the toilet, with your knees bent and your feet on a stool. This can help you use the right muscles to empty your bowel
- Not putting off going to the toilet
- Firmly massaging your stomach area in a clockwise movement can help get your bowel moving and can ease bloating and wind

Where can I get more help?

Your GP or healthcare team can give you medicine to help with constipation. They may give you stool softeners for hard poo that is difficult to pass or laxatives for a slow bowel habit. Only take these under medical guidance.

Wind

Your bowel habits may have changed after treatment and you may experience wind. These symptoms may improve after a few months, but some people have longer-term changes. Changing your diet can help to improve your symptoms.

Everyone passes wind. Although this can be embarrassing, it's normal. You may pass wind through your mouth (belching) or through your bottom (flatulence). Speak to your GP or healthcare team if you are having a lot of wind or pain in your stomach area.

What causes wind?

Bacteria are present in everyone's large bowel. They produce wind as they break down the food you eat. But sometimes you may have too much wind or trapped wind. This can make you feel bloated, full, sick or uncomfortable. You may get shooting pains in your stomach area or pains that come and go (colic). If you have a stoma, you won't be able to control when you pass wind into your stoma bag.

You may also get wind and other bowel problems after bowel cancer treatment, such as radiotherapy, surgery or chemotherapy.

Swallowing air when you eat or drink can cause wind. You may swallow too much air if you eat quickly or talk while you eat. Some people swallow air as a nervous habit or if they have a problem with stomach acid.

If you have constipation, food can sit in your large bowel for longer, which can cause wind. You can find out more about constipation on [page 32](#).

You may find that some types of food and drink cause more wind. You can use the food and symptoms diary on [page 41](#) to help you find out what is causing the problem.

If you think you know what food is causing your wind, you could try eating less of it to see if that helps. You could also change the way you eat it. For example, if raw vegetables are causing wind, you could try eating them cooked instead. Don't cut out whole groups of food or make big changes to your diet without speaking to your healthcare team or a dietitian.

Food and drinks that can cause wind in some people include:

- peas, beans and lentils
- some vegetables, including broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, Brussels sprouts, onions, asparagus, cucumbers, garlic, leeks, mushrooms and sweetcorn
- fructose, a sugar found naturally in fruit and also in some processed foods
- sorbitol and mannitol, which are sweeteners found in sugar-free sweets, chewing gum and some chocolate
- fatty foods, such as fried foods, creamy sauces and cakes
- fruit juices, if you drink more than one glass a day
- sparkling water and fizzy drinks
- wine and beer

How can diet help?

- Avoid missing meals. Have a snack and drink if there's a long gap between meals
- Sit up straight when you're eating and try to avoid lying down during the day
- Take your time when you're eating and drinking to avoid swallowing too much air
- Make sure you're drinking enough fluid but avoid fizzy drinks
- Avoid sugar-free chewing gum and sucking on boiled sweets, as these contain sweeteners and make you swallow more than usual
- If you're trying to eat more fibre, add it to your diet gradually. Eating too much in one go can cause wind and can make constipation worse
- Drinking peppermint tea can help to reduce wind

-
- Eating oats and linseeds (also called flaxseeds) can help with wind and bloating. Try oat-based breakfast cereals or porridge. Add up to one tablespoon of ground or milled linseeds to your meals each day. This doesn't include linseed oil, which doesn't contain fibre. You will need to add more fluids to your meal when you eat linseeds
 - There's limited evidence, but some people find that probiotic supplements help with wind and bloating. Always check with your healthcare team before taking probiotics and don't take them during cancer treatment. If you try probiotic supplements, take the dose recommended by the manufacturer and take them for at least four weeks to see if

they're helping. If you eat probiotic yoghurts, check that they don't contain artificial sweeteners as these can cause wind

What else can I do to reduce wind?

Be as active as you can. Regular gentle physical activity can help prevent constipation and reduce wind. Avoid using drinking straws and don't smoke as these make you swallow more air than usual.

Can diet help prevent bowel cancer coming back?

We don't yet know how to stop bowel cancer coming back after treatment. There's some suggestion that the following things may help reduce your risk of cancer coming back, but we need more research and evidence to fully understand this.

Keeping well after treatment

- Stay a healthy weight. Measuring your body mass index (BMI) is one way of finding out if you're a healthy weight for your height. Visit the NHS website for information on BMI
- If you're able to, be physically active for at least 30 minutes a day and spend less time sitting down
- Avoid high-calorie food and sugary drinks
- Eat more wholegrains, vegetables, fruit and beans
- Limit red meat and avoid processed meat
- Avoid alcohol if possible. If you do drink alcohol, drink no more than 14 units a week and spread it out over the week, with at least two alcohol-free days a week

Making healthy lifestyle choices is good for your overall health and can prevent or reduce other health problems, such as diabetes and heart disease.

More support

Speak to your GP or healthcare team if you have any worries about your diet or your ability to keep physically active. They may refer you to another health professional, such as a dietitian or physiotherapist.

Getting professional support

Do I need to see a specialist?

Ask to see a dietitian if you have:

- diabetes
- a long-term health condition that affects what you can eat, such as high cholesterol, high blood pressure, gall stones, diverticulitis, coeliac disease or inflammatory bowel disease
- food allergies or sensitivities
- unintended weight loss
- side effects of treatment that affect your ability to eat, such as sickness, diarrhoea, fatigue or mouth sores
- low anterior resection syndrome (LARS)– this is a long-term bowel condition that some people may experience after some types of rectal cancer surgery. For more information about LARS, visit **bowelcanceruk.org.uk**

A physiotherapist can help if you have extreme tiredness (fatigue) or need help getting your strength and fitness back. Physiotherapists can also help with other problems caused by bowel cancer and its treatment.

For example, if surgery has caused you to lose control of your bowel, they can show you pelvic floor exercises that may help. You can find more ways to help you regain bowel control on our website at **bowelcanceruk.org.uk**

Health and wellbeing events

Some hospitals offer health and wellbeing events where you can find information on managing your health and wellbeing after cancer treatment. This may include information on diet and lifestyle. You may also have the chance to meet other people facing the same issues as you to share tips and advice.

Some hospitals also offer holistic needs assessments, which aim to find out what practical or physical needs you have. Your healthcare team may refer you to other local services if you need them. Your specialist nurse can tell you if these events or assessments are available at your hospital.

Eating well: things to remember

- Speak to your healthcare team or a dietitian before making any big changes to your diet
- Try to eat a healthy, balanced diet
- Make meal and snack times enjoyable, for example by having some of your favourite food and drinks
- Be as physically active as you can
- If you don't feel like eating, you could try eating smaller amounts more often or drinking high-calorie drinks
- If you're trying to eat more fibre, add it to your diet gradually to avoid wind, bloating and stomach cramps
- If your healthcare team have advised you to follow a low-fibre diet, you could try eating foods containing soluble fibre, such as well-cooked vegetables with the skin and seeds removed
- Tell your healthcare team if you're taking any food supplements. It's important not to take any vitamins or supplements during cancer treatment unless your healthcare team has recommended them
- Our food and symptoms diary may help you find out which foods are causing any bowel symptoms – see [page 41](#)

Food and symptoms diary

Keeping a diary of food and symptoms may help you find out which foods you react to. Include the amount of food you eat as well as how long any reactions last.

You may get symptoms up to a day after you eat the food. You could share your diary with your dietitian or healthcare team, who can give you advice.

Date and time	Food, drinks and medicine taken	How much?	What was the symptom or reaction?	How long did it last?

You can download copies of this diary from bowelcanceruk.org.uk/ourpublications

Words used in this booklet

Carbohydrate	A nutrient needed by the body for energy
Colostomy	Where a section of the large bowel is brought out through an opening on your abdomen, allowing bowel motions (poo) to pass into a bag (appliance or pouch)
Dietitian	A healthcare professional who diagnoses and treats nutritional problems and helps people make good diet choices
Fat	A food type that is important for energy, helping the body absorb some vitamins and keeping the brain and nervous system healthy. Should only be eaten in small amounts
Fibre	The part of plant foods that the body can't digest. Fibre helps to keep the bowel healthy
Ileostomy	Where a section of small bowel is brought out through an opening on your abdomen, allowing bowel motions (poo) to pass into a bag (appliance or pouch)
Minerals	A type of nutrient that your body needs in small amounts to stay healthy
Nutrients	Substances in food needed for good health, such as protein, fat, carbohydrate, vitamins and minerals
Protein	Needed by the body for growth and repair and to keep muscles and bones healthy
Vitamins	A type of nutrient that your body needs in small amounts to stay healthy

Other useful organisations

Bladder & Bowel UK

W bbuk.org.uk

T 0161 214 4591

UK charity for people with bladder and bowel problems.

British Dietetic Association

W bda.uk.com

Provides information on healthy eating and how to find a dietitian.

Cancer Research UK

W cancerresearchuk.org

T 0808 800 4040

Information for people affected by cancer. You can speak to an information nurse by calling their helpline.

Chartered Society of Physiotherapy

W csp.org.uk

For information on what physiotherapy is and a searchable list of qualified physiotherapists.

Colostomy UK

W colostomyuk.org

T 0800 328 4257

Provides support, reassurance and practical information to anyone who has or is about to have a stoma.

Food Standards Agency

W food.gov.uk

T 0330 332 7149

For information on the Eatwell guide.

IA (Ileostomy and Internal Pouch Support Group)

W iasupport.org

T 0800 018 4724

A network of support groups run by and for people with ileostomies and internal pouches.

Macmillan Cancer Support

W macmillan.org.uk

T 0808 808 0000

Provides support and information for people with cancer, including information on diet and recipes.

NHS

W [nhs.uk](https://www.nhs.uk)

The UK's biggest health website.

NHS 111 Wales

W 111.wales.nhs.uk

NHS health information for Wales.

NHS Inform

W nhsinform.scot

Health information for Scotland.

Health and Social Care Northern Ireland

W online.hscni.net/

NHS health information for
Northern Ireland.

Pelvic Radiation Disease Association

W prda.org.uk

Information and support for people
with pelvic radiation disease, which
is a possible long-term side effect of
pelvic radiotherapy.

Penny Brohn UK

W pennybrohn.org.uk

T 0303 3000 118

Helps people live well with cancer
by offering a range of free services,
including information, courses and
demonstrations on healthy eating
and cooking.

World Cancer Research Fund

W wcrf-uk.org

Promotes scientific research on
cancer prevention and survival
through diet, weight and physical
activity to help people make
informed lifestyle choices.

More support



Online communities

Join our forum and Facebook groups for everyone affected by bowel cancer at **[bowelcanceruk.org.uk/online-communities](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/online-communities)**



Publications

We produce a range of expert information to support anyone affected by bowel cancer. Order or download our free publications at **[bowelcanceruk.org.uk/ourpublications](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/ourpublications)**



Website

Visit our website for a range of information about bowel cancer including symptoms, risk factors, screening, diagnosis, treatment and living with and beyond the disease. Visit **[bowelcanceruk.org.uk](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk)**



Ask the nurse

If you have any questions about bowel cancer, contact our nurses at **[bowelcanceruk.org.uk/nurse](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/nurse)**



Support events

Learn about the disease from experts at our support events for those affected by bowel cancer, including family and friends at **[bowelcanceruk.org.uk/supportevents](https://www.bowelcanceruk.org.uk/supportevents)**

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Bowel Cancer UK is the UK's leading bowel cancer charity. We're determined to save lives and improve the quality of life of everyone affected by the disease.

We support and fund targeted research, provide expert information and support to patients and their families, educate the public and professionals about bowel cancer and campaign for early diagnosis and access to best treatment and care.

To donate or find out more visit
bowelcanceruk.org.uk

 [/bowelcanceruk](https://www.facebook.com/bowelcanceruk)

 [@bowelcanceruk](https://twitter.com/bowelcanceruk)

Trusted
Information
Creator



Patient Information Forum

Please contact us if you have any comments about the information in this booklet: feedback@bowelcanceruk.org.uk

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